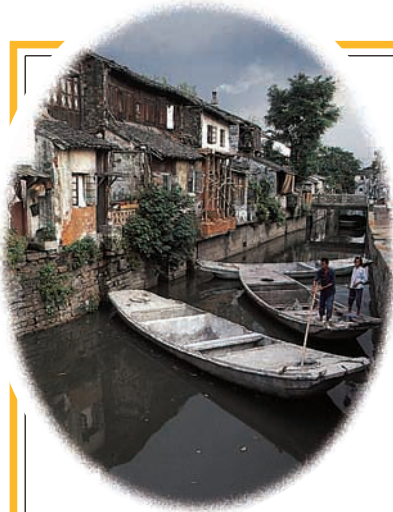




THE GRAND CANAL

The world's longest waterway, the Grand Canal, stretches for 1,110 miles (1,790 km) across China. It was begun in the 5th century BC to connect the cities of the north with the rice growing valleys of the south. Near its southern end, the canal passes through Suzhou, a picturesque city known as the "Venice of the East" because it is crisscrossed by rivers and canals.

LIFE IN THE PARK

Because most city people live in apartments with no yards, parks play an important part in everyone's life. Exercise is encouraged in China, and people go regularly to the park to stay in shape. Early in the morning, many people practice *tai chi* or the more vigorous *kung-fu*. Children fly kites on windy days, and adults play table tennis, cards, or chess, or just sit and chat with their friends.



INDUSTRY

Over the last 20 years China has transformed itself from one of the world's poorest nations into a rapidly expanding economy. It is a leading producer of textiles, clothing, and electronics. Western-style market reforms have led to a surge in growth and the rise of cities such as Shanghai, with its new, futuristic economic quarter, Pudong (pictured). However, in spite of this, much of the population remains very poor.

THE BUDDHISTS OF TIBET

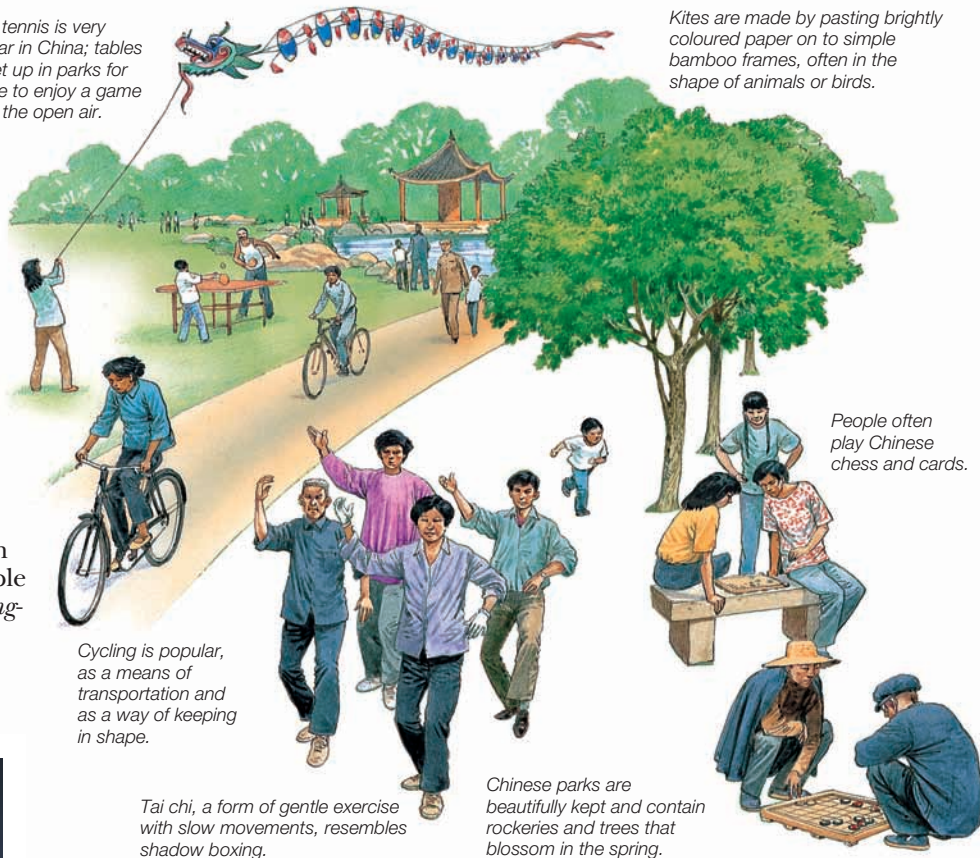
Tibet, once an independent country, has been part of China since 1950. Tibetans are devout Buddhists and their religion has been suppressed by the Communist Party, which discourages any religious practice. However, the Buddhist faith remains strong in Tibet. Buddhists devote their lives to prayer. They hang up flags with prayers printed on them to bring fortune and good luck.



Tibetan Buddhists hang prayer flags from their houses, across bridges, or on mountainsides.

Table tennis is very popular in China; tables are set up in parks for people to enjoy a game out in the open air.

Kites are made by pasting brightly coloured paper on to simple bamboo frames, often in the shape of animals or birds.



Cycling is popular, as a means of transportation and as a way of keeping in shape.

Tai chi, a form of gentle exercise with slow movements, resembles shadow boxing.

Chinese parks are beautifully kept and contain rockeries and trees that blossom in the spring.

People often play Chinese chess and cards.

CHINESE MEDICINE

The Chinese believe that a person becomes sick because the opposing forces of *yin* and *yang* in the body become unbalanced. Doctors rebalance the body with herbal remedies and acupuncture, which involves sticking thin needles into various parts of the body to relieve pain. Many people are treated by "barefoot doctors," or locally trained healers.

Senn leaf (*fan xie ye*) is a herb used to cleanse the system.



Bugbane rhizome (*sheng ma*) is used to treat headaches, colds, and measles.



Wolfberry (*guo qi zi*) is used for diabetes and is said to improve eyesight.



Chain fern bark (*gou ji*) helps ease back pain.